The Care Arrangement Gap Checklist

The helpers, backups and open questions to write down while Mom's week is working.

A neighbor drives Mom to her appointments, your brother handles the bills, and you call every evening. It works, and all of it lives in people's heads. This checklist is for getting it onto paper in a week when nothing is pressing. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something to get to when it suits, and it says nothing about how Mom is doing.

List

- [ ] Everyone who helps Mom in an ordinary week and what each one does, including the people who'd say they don't do much.
- [ ] The small regular things as well as the big ones: the ride to an appointment, the bills, the phone call every evening.
- [ ] Next to each task, who else could do it. Where you can't name anyone, write “only them.” [1]
- [ ] The “only them” tasks again, together in one place, your own included.
- [ ] Any notes the family already has about Mom's week: a list someone started, or anything a professional has written that she's chosen to share.

Note

- [ ] Every backup the family mentions, even in passing, such as “Aunt Carol would step in.” Beside each one: “agreed,” or “assumed” if nobody has asked.
- [ ] Anything in Mom's week that is done some of the time, or by nobody yet, written as what happens now and not as what's wrong with it.
- [ ] The parts of her week that aren't chores: who she sees, who she talks to, and the things she likes to do.
- [ ] Where two of you remember an arrangement differently, or nobody is sure: both versions, and who said each.

Ask

- [ ] Mom: how the week looks from her side, and what she would add to the list or take off it. [1]
- [ ] Each person who helps: whether the list has their part right, and how that part fits with the rest of their week. [1]
- [ ] Each person the family thinks of as a backup: whether they'd be willing, and for which parts. Write down what they say. [2]
- [ ] Each other: who will follow up on each open line, and what kind of change would bring the family back to this list.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you list, note and ask. It doesn't say whether Mom's arrangement is enough, whether anything should be added, or when anything might change. Those belong to Mom and to the professionals who assess her, and to the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've listed who helps, noted which backups have been agreed, and asked the people involved. The care interview walks through Mom's daily life area by area, including the parts that are fine today, so your list sits inside a fuller picture, and it turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow the National Institute on Aging's page on sharing caregiving, which suggests asking who else can step in and checking in with the older person and the other caregivers. The item marked 2 follows the Family Caregiver Alliance's page on backup planning, which says to talk with a likely helper about their willingness to step in. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Smart Caregiving by FCA: Backup Planning